Where the Eye Goes First

A short course in visual hierarchy, scanning patterns, and the Gestalt principles that decide, in a fraction of a second, whether a user finds your CTA or bounces off your page.

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UI · UX · Web design

01 — FIRST IMPRESSIONS

Users don't read pages.
They scan them.

Before a visitor reads a single word, their eyes have already made three decisions: where to look first, what matters most, and what to do next.

Good interface design doesn't fight this behavior, it embraces it. Every layout choice you make (size, weight, color, spacing, position) is a signal telling the eye where to travel. When those signals are intentional, the page feels effortless. When they're accidental, the eye wanders and the user loses interest

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Design is the art of controlling attention. Everything in this presentation is a tool for directing that attention.

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02 — EYE-TRACKING PATTERNS

The F-Pattern

For text-heavy pages, such as blogs, articles, search results.
The eye sweeps across the top, makes a shorter second pass, then drops straight down the left edge.

TYPICAL SCAN PATH ON AN ARTICLE PAGE



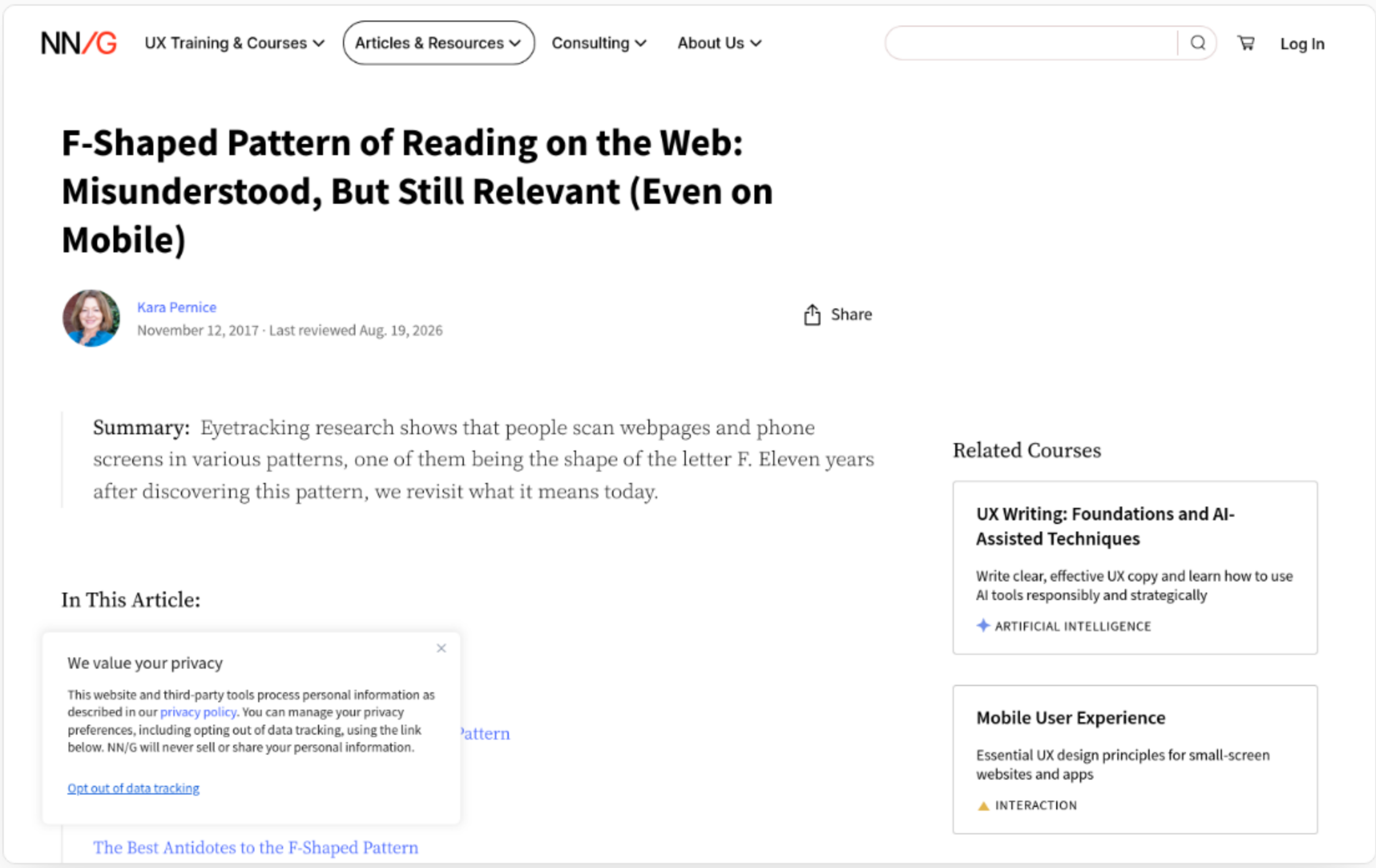
HOW TO DESIGN FOR IT

Load the front of each line. The first two words of every heading and paragraph carry the most weight, so be sure to front-load importance.

Punctuate the left margin. Bullets, subheadings, and **bold** phrases on the left edge catch the downward sweep of the eye.

Put key content in the top bar. The first horizontal pass is the most thorough scan the page ever gets, so prioritize appropriately

NEVER bury the CTA bottom-right. The right side of a text page is a dead zone for long-form reading (stick the ads down there).



In the wild: this article from Nielsen Norman Group — the team that first documented the F-pattern — is itself a text-heavy page read in an F. Headline, subheadings, and bold lead-ins punctuate the top bar and left margin exactly where the eye sweeps.

The Z-Pattern

On low-text layouts such as landing pages, hero sections, the eye traces a Z: logo top-left, menu top-right, a diagonal drop, then across to the final action bottom-right.

SCAN PATH ON A MINIMAL LANDING PAGE



DESIGN IMPLICATIONS

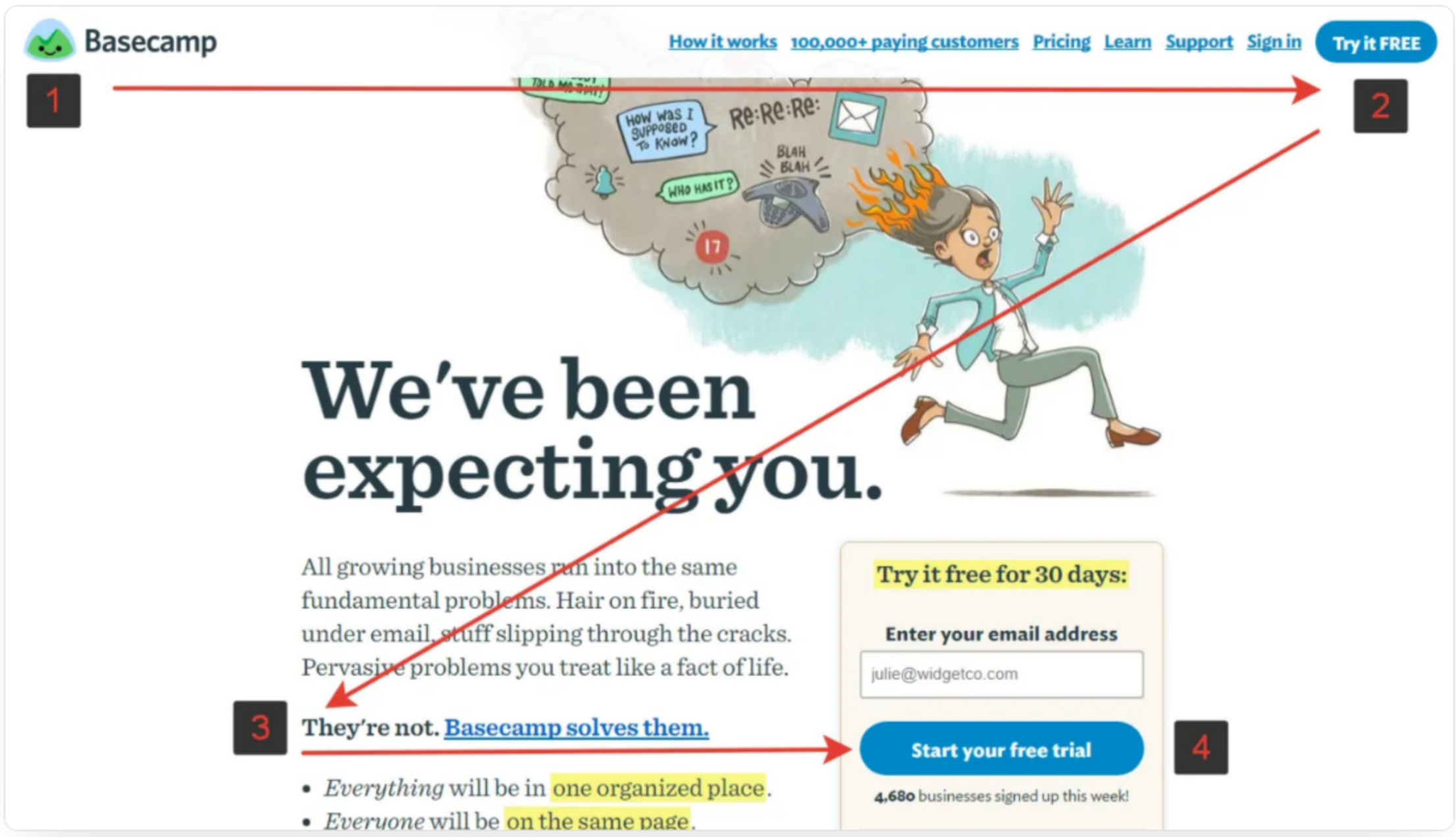
The Z-pattern is ideal for pages with less text and more visual content, such as landing pages or home pages. Your eyes follow a “Z” shape: starting at the top left, moving to the right, then diagonally to the bottom left, and then to the right again.

Stop 1 - Top-left: Like the F-pattern, begin with crucial elements like the logo and navigation at the top.

Stop 2 - Top-right: the menu or *secondary* CTA, the eye exits the first pass here.

The diagonal: prime real estate for a splash image or headline that carries the visitor down the page.

Stop 4 - Bottom-right: Place a strong CTA at the final point of the Z, usually at the bottom right. End the journey where the eye naturally stops.



In the wild: Basecamp's landing page is a textbook Z, logo top-left, menu top-right, a bold diagonal of visual weight carrying the eye down, and the call-to-action waiting at the end of the path.

Gaze Direction

Human eyes are built to follow other eyes. Where a face looks, we look — which means the people and characters in your imagery are aiming your users.



The face is looking here — and so is the user.

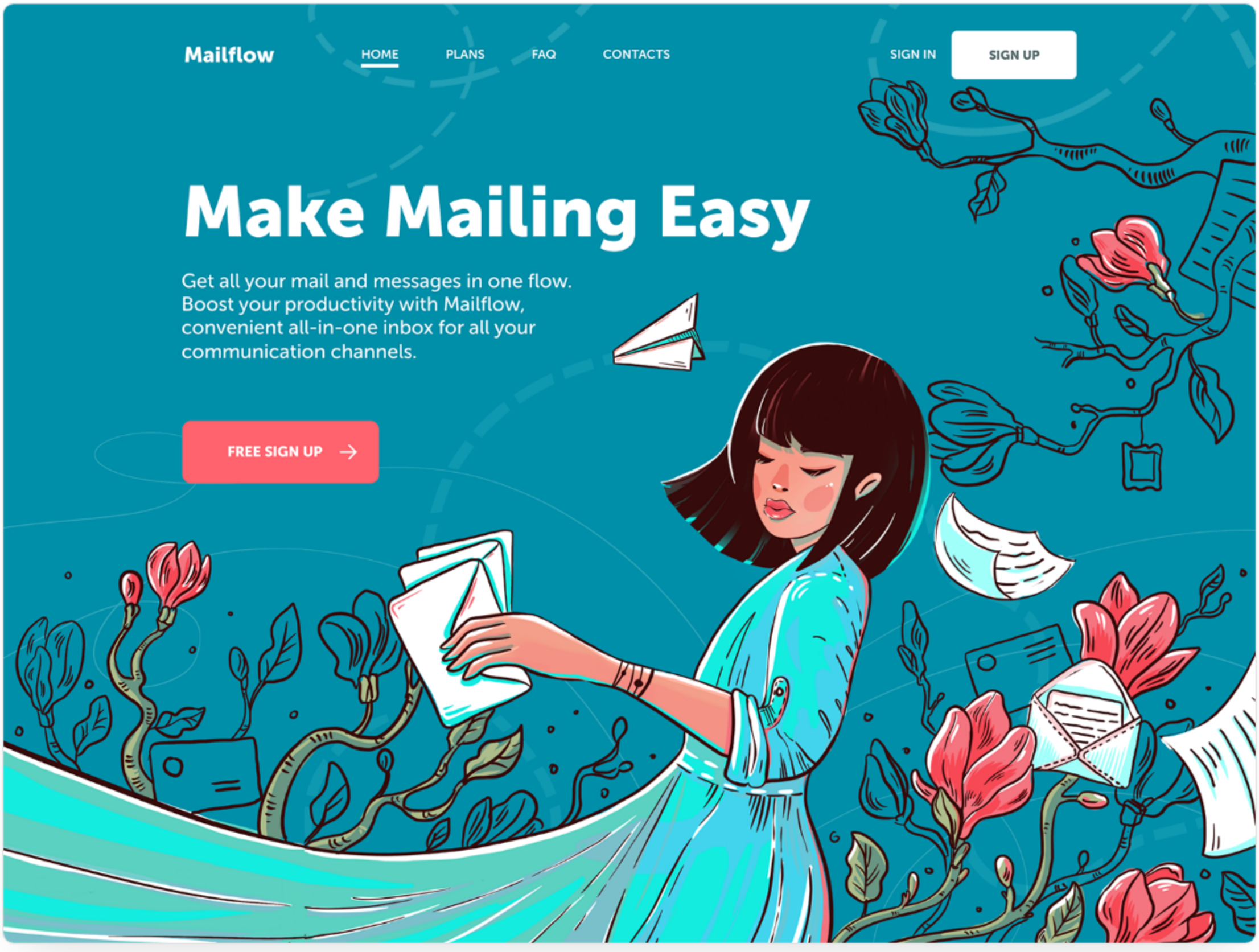
Point every face, arrow, and figure toward the element that earns the click.

GET STARTED

This is why stock photos of models staring at the camera often underperform: a face aimed at the viewer aims the viewer right back at itself. A face aimed at your headline, your form, or your button turns photography into a signpost.

Gaze Direction, In the Wild

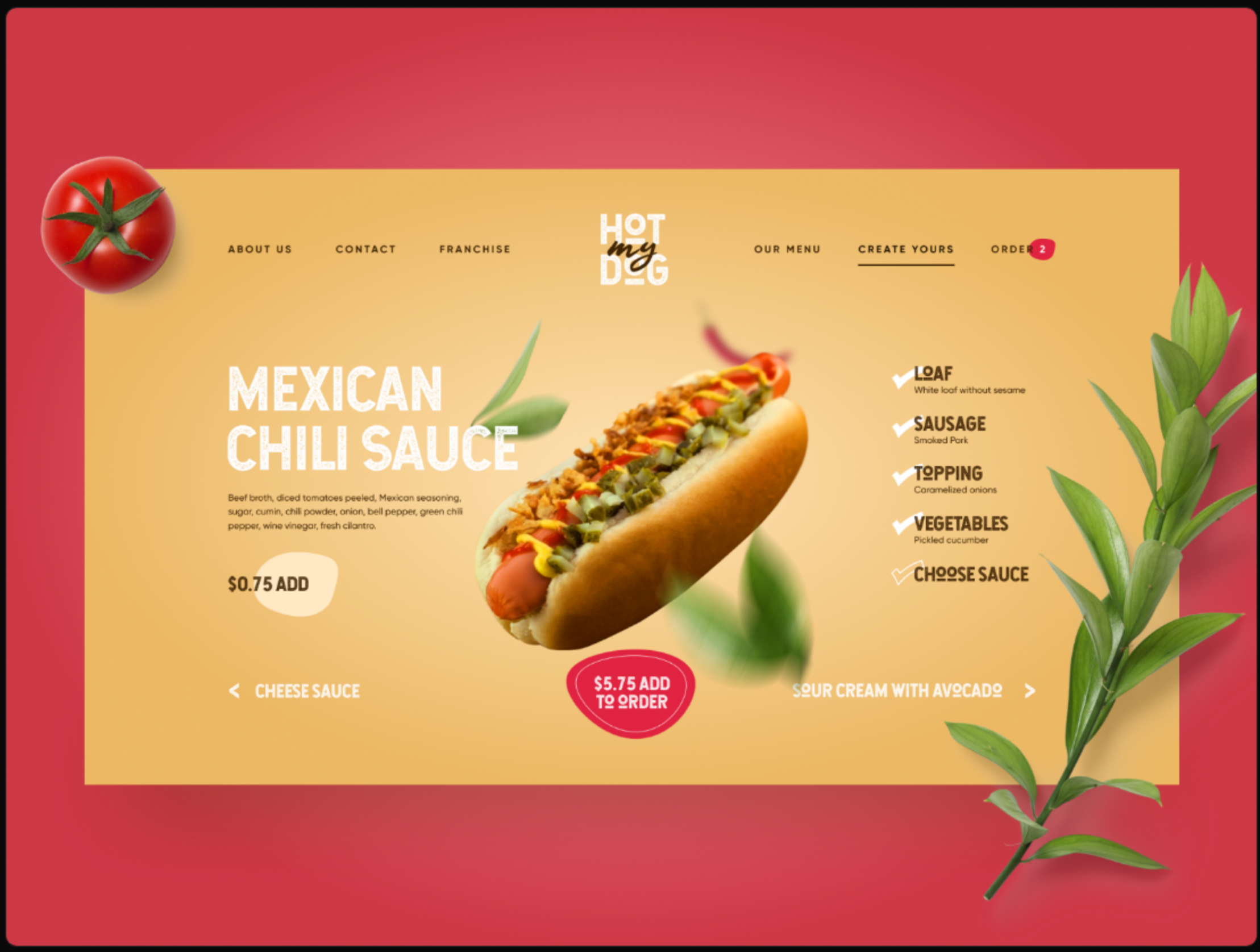
Mailflow's illustrated landing page. The character isn't decoration, its line of sight is aimed straight at the page's focal point. The paper airplanes and flowers(? do the same.



Mailflow's landing page — the character's line of sight leads the eye directly into the layout's focal point.

Gaze Direction, In the Wild

The same trick but without a person! Here the hot dog draws the eyes and funnels attention toward the product and its call to action.



07 — DRAWING THE EYE

Visual Hierarchy

Make the most important element on the screen the largest, boldest, or brightest thing there. Then step everything else down — deliberately.

FLAT — EVERYTHING SHOUTS, NOTHING IS HEARD

Launch faster than ever

Our platform helps teams ship in days, not months

Trusted by 2,000 companies

Start free trial

No credit card required

HIERARCHICAL — THREE CLEAR STEPS OF IMPORTANCE

NEW · V2.0

Launch faster

Ship in days, not months

Trusted by 2,000 companies. No credit card required.

START FREE TRIAL

A practical rule: use **two to three distinct font sizes**, never five similar ones. Distinct steps read as a hierarchy; similar sizes read as noise.

08 — DRAWING THE EYE

Contrast & Color

The eye is a difference detector. Bright or high-contrast elements pull focus away from muted, neutral surroundings — which is exactly why accent colors must be spent, not scattered.



One dark card on a field of gray — no color required. Contrast comes from at least three dials you can turn: **value** (light vs. dark), **size**, and **weight**. Color is a fourth dial, and the easiest to overuse: if everything is an accent, nothing is. Pick one accent color, reserve it for the actions you most want taken, and let muted neutrals carry the rest of the page.

If you can't say which element on a page is the most important one, the page is saying all of them equally — which means none of them.

Proximity & White Space

The brain reads things that sit close together as belonging together, and reads things floating in empty space as important enough to stand alone.

UNIFORM SPACING: EVERYTHING BLURS INTO ONE WALL

Hosted Postgres
Managed backups, point-in-time recovery, zero config.

Edge Caching
Static assets served from 300 locations worldwide.

Team Access
Roles, SSO, and audit logs on every plan.

Usage Analytics
Per-project dashboards with hourly granularity.

GROUPED: CATEGORIES EMERGE ON THEIR OWN

Hosted Postgres
Managed backups, point-in-time recovery, zero config.

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Static assets served from 300 locations worldwide.

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Same four cards, same content...but on the right side, tight spacing inside each pair and generous spacing between pairs makes two groups appear without drawing a single border.

White space around a key element does the same job in reverse: **surrounded by nothing, an element becomes the page's resting point for the eye.** Crowded pages don't fail because they're ugly...they fail because user's don't know what content matters...

Gestalt Principles

In the 1920s, German psychologists showed that the brain perceives whole patterns before it perceives parts. These principles are why the layout tricks in this deck work.



PROXIMITY

Elements near each other are seen as a group. The basis of grouping cards, labels, and form fields.



SIMILARITY

Things that look alike are read as related. The basis of consistent buttons, links, and tag styles.



CLOSURE

The mind completes incomplete shapes. The basis of skeleton loaders, progress rings, and icons.

Two more concepts show up constantly in web work: **continuity**, the eye prefers smooth, uninterrupted paths, which is why aligned rows and carousels read so naturally, and **figure/ground**, the brain separates a focal element from its background, which is what makes a modal or a floating action button instantly legible.

Working memory is a budget.

Every element on a screen competes for the same limited cognitive bandwidth. If a user spends their mental energy filtering out clutter, they have no bandwidth left to actually comprehend your content.

That is the theory underneath everything in this deck. And it is why white space is not empty space...it is the active structural fix that prevents cognitive overload. Think of it as a shock absorber for attention:

01 **It creates visual hierarchy.** Ample spacing isolates elements, telling the brain automatically: look at this first, then look at that.

02 **It facilitates chunking.** Breaking long blocks of text into smaller, spaced-out fragments lets working memory process information in bite-sized pieces instead of one overwhelming wall.

03 **It promotes breathing room.** Micro white space (between lines and words) and macro white space (between layout blocks) lowers anxiety, making an interface feel calm, premium, and manageable.

12 — AFTER THE EYE LANDS

Every choice costs time.

Hick's Law: the time it takes to make a decision increases logarithmically as the number of choices grows. A few extra options cost little. At scale, they cost you the decision itself.

STREAMING SERVICES

Opening a platform with thousands of titles often causes choice paralysis: making it harder to pick anything to watch at all. The catalogue is the product and the problem.

RESTAURANTS

Popular eateries keep their menus short on purpose: customers choose faster, and table turnover improves. Fewer options isn't a limitation...it's a benefit sometimes.

How to solve for it

01 **Minimize choices.** Keep navigation menus and primary action buttons short. Every item costs cognitive energy.

02 **Highlight recommendations.** Feature a "most popular" or "recommended" plan in pricing tables to guide the user's eye where you want.

03 **Break up complex tasks.** Split long multi-step processes, like a checkout flow, into smaller, manageable screens.

TRY IT — CLICK THE LETTER A AS FAST AS YOU CAN

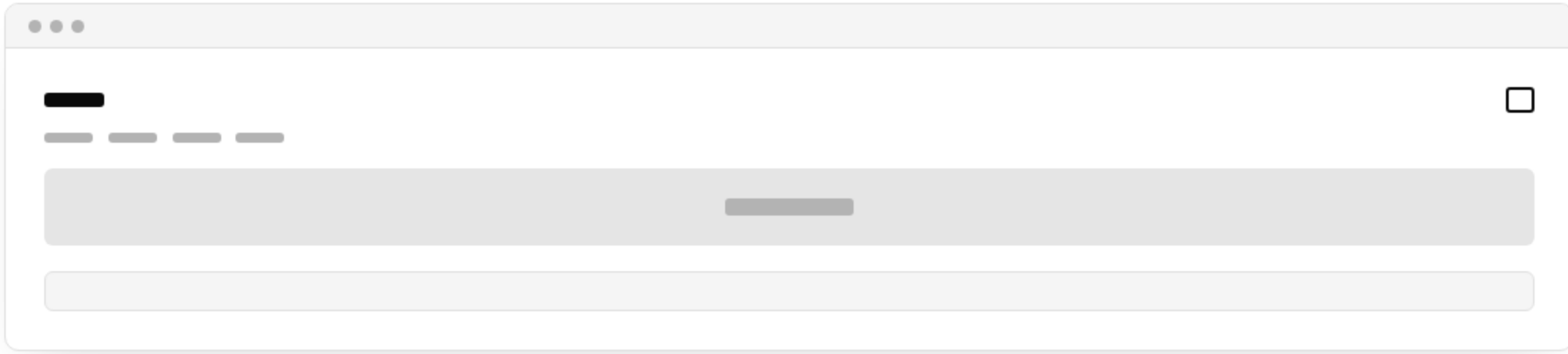
ROUND 1 — 4 OPTIONS

A D B C

Your site works like the internet.

Jakob's Law (Jakob Nielsen, 2000): users spend most of their time on other websites...so they expect yours to work like the ones they already know.

Every visitor arrives with a pre-built mental model of how the internet works, shaped by Amazon, Google, Apple, and Netflix. Whether you run a tiny boutique shop or a massive corporate blog, the expectations are the same. Break a convention and you force users to learn a new system just to navigate your content.



01 **The logo:** top-left or top-center, and clicking it always returns to the homepage. Always. ALWAYS. ALWAYS!!!!

02 **The navigation bar:** fixed across the top of the screen, or hidden inside a standard hamburger icon on mobile.

03 **The shopping cart:** in the upper right-hand corner.

04 **The footer:** contact information, terms of service, and social links at the very bottom of the page.

Familiarity is a feature. Creative navigation placement is a tax on every visitor.

14 — AFTER THE EYE LANDS

Components.

The principles in this presentation don't stop at the page level, they show up inside every component you build.

CARDS

A card is a Gestalt claim: everything inside the boundary belongs together. One card, one idea, one action, and the whole card should be clickable, not just the title. A half-clickable card is not an optimal design pattern.

SLIDERS

Great for feel, terrible for precision. Volume, or a price range with live updates is perfect. Entering an exact value...use a number field. If you must ship a slider, pair it with a numeric input and always show the current value. A naked slider handle is a guessing game.

BUTTONS & TOUCH TARGETS

One primary action per view, visually dominant; everything else should be secondary or ghost styled. Buttons get verb labels: "Create account," never "Submit." And 44×44px minimum, thumb-reachable on mobile: that's known as Fitts's Law.

15 — AFTER THE EYE LANDS

Design the edge cases.

The component isn't done when it works. It's done when its failure states are designed.

01 **Loading, empty, error.** Errors should say what happened and what to do next. Most "bad UI" is really just undesigned edge states.

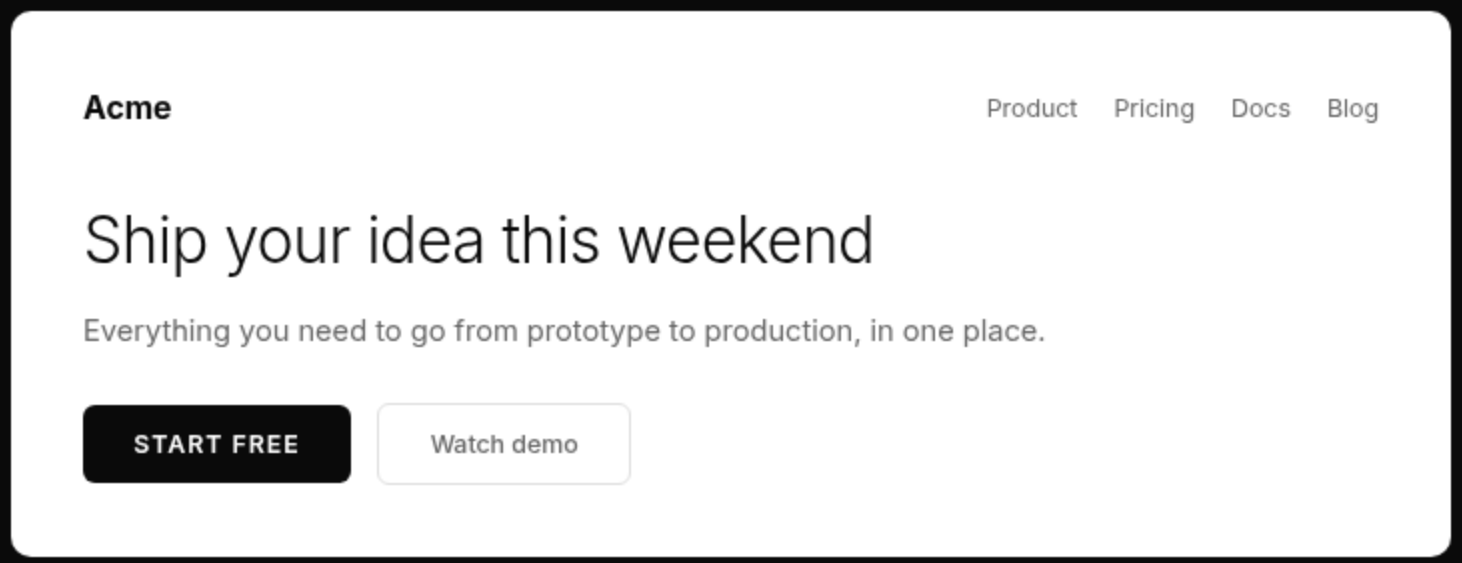
02 **Modals are an interruption.** If it can be a panel, a drawer, or an inline section, it should be. Reserve modals for decisions that genuinely must block the page.

03 Show, don't make them

16 — THE PRACTICE TEST

The Blur Test

Screenshot your page, apply a 5–10px Gaussian blur, and look again. If you can't instantly tell what the main button or focal point is, your visual hierarchy needs adjustment.



APPLY BLUR

Can you still tell where the eye is supposed to land?

Blurring removes detail and leaves only contrast, size, and weight, the exact signals a first-time visitor processes in their first glance. If "Start Free" still dominates through the blur, your hierarchy works. If the nav, the headline, and the button compete evenly, they all lose.

A Practical Checklist

Eight checks to run on any layout before you ship it.

01 **Name the one action.** Write down the single most important element on the page. If you can't, the page has no hierarchy yet.

02 **Check the pattern.** Text-heavy page ⇒ design for the F. Low-text landing page ⇒ design for the Z.

03 **Limit the scale.** Two or three distinct type sizes and weights. Distinct steps create order, similar ones create noise.

04 **Use contrast, don't scatter it.** One accent, reserved for the primary action, against a quiet neutral field.

05 **Group with proximity.** Related items tight, unrelated items far. Let spacing do the labeling before you add borders.

06 **Run the blur test.** Blur (or squint, that works too) the focal point should survive the loss of all detail.

07 **Count the choices.** Every menu, pricing table, and form step. Decision time grows with option count...cut before you decorate.

08 **Design the states.** Loading, empty, error. A component isn't done until its failure states are.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Users don't read. They follow the signals you leave.

Size, contrast, position, spacing, and gaze. Every element on a page is either aiming the eye or distracting it. Design the path first, the decoration second. And after the eye lands: fewer choices, familiar patterns, one clear action.